JAMES

Conversational Version

Salutation

1:**1**James, servant of God and the Lord Jesus Christ[Messiah], to the twelve tribes in the Dispersion. Greetings.

Temptation, Wisdom, Humility

2Consider temptation something to be glad about. **3**It challenges your faith to produce stamina, **4**and stamina gives you the ability to finish what you're doing.

5If you need wisdom, ask God. He gives it generously to everybody without blaming *them for asking*. **6**Trust him when you ask. If you doubt, you're like an ocean wave blown around by the wind. **7**Don't suppose you'll get anything from God. **8**If you can't make up your mind, you're unsettled about everything you do. **James 1:1-8**

9Disciples in humble circumstances should take pride in their high position. **10**Rich disciples should take pride in their humble circumstances because their wealth will fade away like a flower in the grass. **11**The sun climbs high and joins the hot wind to dry up the grass and wilt the flowers, and their beauty fades away. That's how it is with rich people: they wither away in what they're trying to do. **James 1:9-11**

12When you hold up under temptation you're blessed. When approved, you'll receive life as a crown. That's what the Lord has promised people that care about him. **13**When you face temptation, don't say, *"God's tempting me."* Evil isn't tempting to God, and he doesn't tempt anybody. **14**Your own lusts are what tempt you, lure you away, entice you. **15**When lust conceives, it bears sin, and sin grows up to produce death. **James 1:12-15**

Listening, Doing, Controlling the Tongue

16Don't get misled. **17**Every good and perfect gift comes down from the Father that enlightens us. There's no wavering or hint of inconsistency with him. **18**He took the initiative in bringing us forth by the message about the truth so we've become a kind of firstfruits among people he created. **James 1:16-18**

19Know *this*: people must be willing to listen, be careful about what they say, and be slow to get mad. **20**People's anger doesn't produce God's goodness. **21**So get rid of filthy ways of living and the excesses that evil brings; humbly yield to the implanted message that can save you. **James 1:19-21**

22Do the word; don't just listen to it and kid yourselves. **23**If you hear *it* and don't do *it*, you're like a fellow that looks in a mirror **24**and forgets what he looked like. **25**When you stare

into the perfect "law," the law of liberty, and continue as a doer, not just a hearer, you'll be blessed in what you do. **James 1:22-25**

[26]If you consider yourself religious but don't control your tongue, you're fooling yourself; your religion is useless. [27]Pure, undefiled religion with God the Father is this: looking after orphans and widows in their hardship and keeping yourselves from getting stained by the world. **James 1:26-27**

No Discrimination Against the Poor

2:[1]Fellow Christians, don't discriminate against people while claiming to have faith in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ. [2]If a man comes into your assembly dressed nice with a gold ring on his finger, and a poor man comes in wearing shabby clothes, [3]and you give preference to the one in fine clothes and say, *"Sit here in a nice place,"* but say to the poor man, *"Stand over there,"* or *"Sit by my footstool,"* [4]aren't you discriminating and makiing judgments from bad motives? **James 2:1-4**

[5]Listen, hasn't God chosen poor people to be rich in faith and inherit the kingdom he promised to people that care about him? [6]But you've looked down on poor people. Don't rich people bully you and take you to court? [7]Don't they slander the good name you wear? [8]But, you do well to fulfill the royal law according to the scripture, ***"Love your neighbor as yourself"*** **[Lev 19:18]**. [9]If you discriminate, you sin, and the Law convicts you of being a sinner. [10]Whoever keeps the whole Law but stumbles in one point, has become liable to the Law *as such*. [11]The One that said, ***"Do not commit adultery"*** **[Ex 20:14; Deut 5:18]** is the same One that said, ***"Do not murder"*** **[Ex 20:13; Deut 5:17]**. If you don't commit adultery but commit murder, you're still a law breaker. [12]Speak and do like people that are evaluated by a "law" of liberty. [13]Condemnation is without mercy to people that haven't shown mercy. Showing mercy is better than criticizing. **James 2:5-13**

Doing *vs.* Believing

[14]What good is it to say you believe but don't do? Believing can't save you, can it? [15] When a brother or sister needs clothes or daily food, what good is it [16]if somebody says, *"Have a good day; keep warm and fed,"* but doesn't give them what they need? [17]It's the same way if belief doesn't do anything; it's dead by itself. **James 2:14-17**

[18]Somebody might say, *"<u>You</u> have belief; <u>I</u> have deeds."* Show me your belief without doing anything, and I'll show you my belief by what I do. [19]You believe there's one God; that's nice. Demons believe *that* too—and tremble. [20]Can't you see that believing without doing is useless? [21]Wasn't our ancestor Abraham justified by what he did when he sacrificed his son Isaac? [22]Belief combined with his deeds; his deeds completed his belief. [23]He fulfilled the scripture that said, ***"Abraham believed God, and God considered him righteous"*** **[Gen 15:6]**, and he was called "God's friend" **[2 Ch 20:7; Is 41:8]**. [24]That shows we're justified by what we do, not

simply by what we believe. [25]The same with Rahab the prostitute; wasn't she justified by what she did when she received the messengers and sent them out a different way? [26]As the body is dead if it doesn't breathe, believing is dead if it doesn't do anything. **James 2:18-26**

More about Controlling the Tongue

3:[1]Not many of you should try to be teachers; you'll get judged more strictly. [2]In lots of ways we all slip up; if we don't slip up in what we say, we're perfect; and we can bridle our whole body. [3]We put bits in horses' mouths so they'll obey us, and we guide their whole body. [4]The same thing with ships. Though they're so big and driven by strong winds, the helmsmen control them with a very small steering paddle wherever they want them to go. [5]The same thing with the tongue. It's a small part of the body, but it makes big claims. **James 3:1-5**

[6]A little spark can set a big forest on fire! [7]People tame all kinds of animals and birds, reptiles and sea creatures; [8]but nobody can tame the tongue; *it's* an uncontrollable evil full of deadly poison. [9]We bless the Lord and Father with it, and *then* curse people made like him. [10]Blessing and cursing from the same mouth! That shouldn't be. [11]Brackish and sweet water don't gush out of the same spring, do they? [12]A fig tree can't bear olives or a vine yield figs, can it? What's salty can't make something sweet. **James 3:6-12**

The Importance of Wisdom

[13]Who's wise and understanding among you? Show it in good, humble, wise living. [14]If you're jealous and selfish, don't act proud and lie *to cover it up*. [15]"Wisdom" like that doesn't come from above; it's earthly, unspiritual, demonic. [16]Where there's jealousy and selfishness, people are unstable and exhibit all kinds of bad behavior. [17]Wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceful, gentle, open to reason, merciful, and yielding good fruits. It doesn't waver or show hypocrisy. [18]Peacemakers use peace to plant righteous fruit. **James 3:13-18**

Effects of Self-Centeredness

4:[1]Where do conflicts and disagreements come from? Don't they come from pleasures at conflict inside you? [2]You want and don't have, you kill and covet and can't get, you quarrel and fight and don't obtain because you don't ask. [3]When you do ask, you don't receive because you ask with the wrong motive: *you ask* so you can spend it on your pleasures. [4]Adulterers, you know, don't you, that friendship with the world amounts to hostility toward God? So whoever wants to be friendly with the world makes himself hostile toward God. [5]Do you suppose the scripture says for no reason, *"The Spirit he put among us yearns to receive exclusive loyalty"?* [6]He gives more grace, ***"God resists the proud, but he gives grace to the humble"*** **[Pro 3:34 LXX]**. [7]So submit to God. Resist the devil, and he'll run from you. [8]Come close to God, and he'll come close to you. Clean *your* hands, you sinners; purify *your* hearts, you with divided loyalties. [9]Be

sad, mourn, and cry. Turn your laughing into mourning, and your lightheartedness into serious-mindedness. [10]Humble yourselves in front of the Lord, and he'll lift you up. **James 4:1-10**

Ban on Criticism

[11]Don't gossip about each other. When you criticize your brother or sister, you're acting like a judge. If you do that, you go from being a doer of the law to serving as a judge for the law. [12]There is one lawgiver and judge that can acquit or execute. Who are you to serve as a judge over your neighbor? **James 4:11-12**

Recognizing Your Dependent Place

[13]Come, come, now, you that say, *"Today or tomorrow we'll go to such and such a city, spend a year, carry on business, make money."* [14]You don't know what tomorrow holds. What's your life but a vapor that appears for a while and vanishes? [15]You should say, *"The Lord willing, we'll live and do this or that."* [16]But you take pride in your bragging; that's not right. [17]If you know to do good and don't do it, you're sinning. **James 4:13-17**

Futility of Wealth

5:[1]Come, come, rich people. Cry out loud over the miseries heading your way. [2]Your wealth has decayed; your clothes are moth-eaten; [3]your gold and silver have tarnished. Their tarnish will testify against you and consume you like fire. They're the 'wealth' you've laid up for your last days! [4]You haven't paid the workers that mowed your fields. Their complaints have gone up to the Lord of hosts. [5]You've lived in self-indulgence and luxury. You've fattened yourselves up at the expense of people you've ruined. [6]You've condemned, you've murdered the Righteous One; he doesn't resist you. **James 5:1-6**

Exhortation to Endurance

[7]So be patient till the Lord comes. A farmer patiently waits for his valuable crop till it gets *its* early and late rains. [8]You be patient too; strengthen your hearts because the Lord's coming soon. [9]Don't complain about each other or you'll be complained about; the judge is standing right outside your doors. [10]Take the *LORD*'s prophets as models of suffering and endurance. [11]We consider them blessed that endured. You've heard about Job's patience, and you know the Lord's compassionate and merciful in the end. **James 5:7-11**

Dispensing with Oaths

[12]Above all, don't swear by the sky, the earth, or anything else. Just say "yes" or "no"; otherwise, you fall under condemnation. **James 5:12**

Calling the Elders

13Is anybody suffering among you? He should pray. Is anybody happy? He should sing.
14Is anybody sick? He should call the church elders. They should pray over him and anoint him with olive oil in the name of the Lord. **15**Prayer with faith will save the sick, and the Lord will raise them up. If they have sinned, God will forgive them. **16**Admit your sins to each other and pray for each other so you'll be healed. A good person's prayer can accomplish a lot. **17**Elijah was a man like us, and he prayed sincerely that it wouldn't rain, and it didn't for three and a half years. **18**He prayed again and it rained, and the ground grew its crops. **James 5:13-18**

Returning the Stray

19Fellow believers, if somebody wanders off from the truth and somebody gets him turned around, **20**he can be sure that returning a sinner from error will save him from death and cover a host of sins. **James 5:19-20**

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